

Romance Is a Discipline

The question that woke me up in my own marriage came in a normal conversation, from a woman who wasn't angry, and it had the answer sitting inside it.

My wife and I were talking about nothing in particular, and she asked when the last time was that I took her on a date.

It hit me like a ton of bricks, because she was right. I counted back. Close to five months, and I hadn't felt one of them go by. You've heard the same advice I have, that a couple should get out once a week. Nobody established that number. Being there is the part that counts.

She wasn't accusing me of anything. She was asking. If there's a stretch like that in your house, you probably don't know how long it is either. You didn't stop loving her. Nothing in a week tells you how long it's been.

The second piece of advice.

My grandfather gave me two things worth keeping about marriage. You've already had the one about giving sixty and expecting forty. The other came when I first got married, and it was harder to take: "Put your wife first. Focus on her because your kids will leave you."

That came off as harsh. It still does. You're supposed to say your family is everything, not rank the people inside it. Here was an old man ranking them out loud to me. He's also the man whose temper I inherited. He got plenty wrong. He got this right.

I think he meant something gentler than it sounded. You pick a partner, and you keep putting her first after the house fills up with people who need you more loudly. The kids grow and go. They're supposed to. She's the one still across from you when they do, and the one who notices first when you drift.

The thing with no deadline.

It makes sense that it faded, and I'd rather say why than let you think you got lazy.

Romance takes real effort, and you only have so much in a day. The more life takes out of you, the less is left over for her. So when a week gets heavy, something goes, and it's never the mortgage or the kid's game at eight on a Saturday. Those shout. They have a day attached and other people watching. Nobody calls you at work because you haven't surprised your wife since March. So romance goes, quietly, and you never catch it.

It isn't only me. My wife has gotten every bit as busy, and we've both forgotten our anniversary in a hard year. Get far enough in and you can laugh about it. We do.

You run the rest of your life on purpose. If you've read any Stoicism, you aimed it at your temper and it held. This is the one corner you never aimed at.

Epictetus was born a slave in the Roman empire, was freed, and became a teacher whose students wrote down what he said. He put it this way nineteen hundred years ago, and he wasn't talking about marriage.

“Every habit and faculty is maintained and increased by the corresponding actions: the habit of walking by walking, the habit of running by running. If you would be a good reader, read; if a writer, write.”

Discourses 2.18, Long trans.

What you keep doing, you keep. Then he turns it around. Go thirty days without reading, he says, and you’ll know the consequence. Romance works like any muscle: the more you use it, the better you get at it. Leave it a while and the first honest attempt feels ridiculous. That’s only what thirty days does.

Her currency, not yours.

Romance is trying to win favor with your wife. It isn’t about you, it’s about her, with a little mystery and surprise. It runs on study, and you can’t win favor with someone you stopped learning about.

Your default here is the golden rule: treat her the way you’d want to be treated. A communication researcher, Milton Bennett, named the problem with that in 1979. The golden rule quietly assumes she’s built like you. People call his version the platinum rule. Treat her the way she wants to be treated, which means finding out what that is.

You’ve probably met the five love languages. It’s a popular list rather than a science, and nobody has shown that matching hers changes anything. As a tactic rather than a philosophy it does one thing well: it makes you look at all five instead of the one you’d reach for. Touch. Saying it out loud. Doing things for her without being asked.

Mine is touch. My favorite part of a week is laying my head in my wife’s lap while we watch TV and having her rub my head. That’s when I feel closest to her.

Hers is acts of service. Her favorite evening is the two of us grilling together, me helping cook, a little wine, laughing and talking while the work gets done. An ordinary night with both people in it.

And acts of service is my lowest. Bringing somebody a coffee, seeing what needs doing before anyone asks. None of it occurs to me on its own. The language I'm worst at is the one she reads best. I didn't choose that, and if it's true in your house you didn't either. It still has to be done.

So your effort can be real and still land flat. You put your back into something in your own language, she thanks you and means it, and it's flat. You carry that for three days deciding she's ungrateful. She isn't. It arrived in a form she doesn't read as love. To her, love is you asking about the meeting she's been dreading, then asking again on Thursday, because you remembered there was a Thursday.

When love arrives in a form that doesn't land for you, the reflex is to overlook it. Effort in the wrong language is still effort, and you owe it a real thank you. Winning favor isn't trading for it, either.

Twenty years ago I took my wife on a short sightseeing flight over Nashville, and I wrote her letters. I haven't done anything like it since, and she's never asked for another flight. She asked about a date. What lands is the detail you kept and the question you came back to. It's the small thing that says I still see you rather than I planned something impressive.

What's still there.

Couples followed over the years don't usually come apart because the fighting starts. They come apart because the warmth stops, and it stops first in the couples who've been at it longest. Partners who feel appreciated tend to be more appreciative back, and the research only says they travel together.

That sounds bleak for about four seconds. Fighting is a problem you have to solve. This is a thing you stopped doing. You can start again, and you may also owe her an apology.

When you stop making an effort, she may stop expecting it from you.

Marcus Aurelius ran the Roman empire and kept a notebook where he argued with himself. He was a Stoic, and the notebook is *Meditations*. In 4.24 he picks up an old line from a philosopher he doesn't name: if you want to be untroubled, do few things. Marcus corrected it. Do the necessary things instead. That list is harder to write, because it makes you say what actually counts.

She's been waiting to be one of the necessary things, and the muscle that puts her there is one you can start using tonight.

THE THING WITH NO DEADLINE

What has no deadline is easiest to neglect.



*the stretch you never felt go by
you didn't stop loving her*

Love rarely becomes urgent. That is why you have to make room for it.

Chapter 12 Distillation — Romance Is a Discipline

Mechanism: The Thing With No Deadline

Conversation sentence: His wife asked him when he'd last taken her on a date, and the honest answer was five months he never felt go by.

Romance takes effort, and effort runs out. So when a week gets heavy, romance is what goes, because it has no deadline attached and nobody watching. Epictetus had already named the mechanism: a habit is kept by doing it, and thirty days off tells you what disuse does. The repair isn't a bigger gesture. It's priority and form: care has to arrive in the shape she reads as care, and the shape you're worst at is usually hers.

Lesson: Marcus Aurelius corrected an old line about doing few things. Do the necessary things instead. Writing that list honestly means saying out loud whether she is on it.

Challenge: You won't catch yourself letting it go, because it never feels like a decision. And the effort you do make will come out in your own language, which is how it can be real and still land flat.

PRACTICE

1. Once a week, on a set day, ask what actually counted that week and whether anything you did was for her alone. If nothing was, the week made that call for you.
2. When she tells you about something she's dreading, write down the day it lands, and ask her about it again on that day. Coming back to it is what says you were listening.
3. Name your own lowest language out loud, and check it against hers. The one you'd never think of is usually the one she reads best.

Pursue Her After You Have Her

There's a difference between the time you gave your wife and the time she actually got. The gap between those two is small enough to miss for years.

She asks if you want to watch a show together. You sit down beside her, and your phone stays in your hand. Halfway through she laughs at something and looks over to see if you caught it. You didn't.

Another night you take her to dinner. You chose the place and made the reservation. Then you spend most of the meal turning over a problem at work. You answer her questions. You aren't really there.

You made time for her both nights, and that counts for something. What she wanted was your attention, and you had it somewhere else.

When the effort changed.

Think about how you acted when you were still hoping she'd say yes to another date. You paid attention to what she enjoyed. You remembered the story about her friend. You brought her something she'd mentioned liking once, and you found places you thought she'd want to go.

Marriage lets you relax, and that's a good thing. You can sit quietly without wondering whether she's losing interest. You know you'll see her tomorrow. That security is a good part of the life you built. It can also make effort feel optional, until you're giving her less than you gave her back when you weren't sure she'd stay.

So you worked to win her, then treated the wedding as proof the work was finished. You still love her. You may have quietly stopped spending any

thought on her.

Epictetus has a rule for this in his Handbook, the *Enchiridion*: “Duties are universally measured by relations.” (*Enchiridion* 30, Long trans.) He was writing about fathers and brothers, but the rule fits a husband. Husband is a role you keep playing, not a title you won once. If you want to be her husband, keep being her husband. You were her suitor before she said yes, and that job stayed open. Saying you loved her on your wedding day was easy. Showing it the following spring took effort. Choosing her this Saturday costs you an afternoon, and that afternoon is how she knows you chose her.

The date you can't plan.

Say you're twelve years into your marriage and you decide to take her out. You want to arrange the whole thing yourself.

The first place that comes to mind is the Italian restaurant she loved when you were dating. Then you try to remember the last time she ordered pasta, and you can't. You know what she liked at twenty-six. You can't name one thing she'd be excited about this Saturday.

So you ask her. She says she'd rather drive out to the lake town an hour north, walk around, and stop wherever looks good. Then she tells you why. She's been saving pictures of a garden she wants to build along the back fence, and there's a nursery up there she's been reading about.

You didn't know that. She's been mentioning small pieces of it for months, and you've been hearing her the way you hear the radio.

The date is the easy part. The following Tuesday, you ask where the first bed is going, and she takes you out in the dark with her phone light to show you the corner she's picked. Nothing about that evening was on the calendar. It

happened because you finally heard about the garden, and then asked about it again.

She's changed across the years you spent in the same house. You've changed too. Asking is useful. Remembering the answer is what she notices.

What it looks like from her side.

When the effort stops, she can tell you've stopped planning for her. Because you assume she'll always be there, she's the one who gets left out of your thinking. The plain word for that is being taken for granted, and it feels like being furniture in her own marriage: known, needed, walked past.

She stops mentioning what she wants, because bringing it up twice was already more than she wanted to do. She organizes her own birthday. She says "whatever you want" because choosing got her nowhere the last three times. She never announces any of it. You end up with a wife who has gotten used to asking for less.

When you finally do plan something, she may not light up the way you pictured. Give it time. She's working out whether this is a change or just an evening.

Be there for the time you share.

If she wants to watch a show, put the phone in a drawer. Whether or not you love the show, you can enjoy sitting beside her, seeing what makes her laugh, and letting an hour belong to the two of you. At dinner, the problem at work can wait until the drive home.

Some nights she wants to tell you about her day. Some nights she wants your company while neither of you says much. You can tell which one it is when

you're paying attention. If your mind wanders, come back to the table. You won't give her every minute perfectly, but you can give her the evening you offered.

She handled something hard this week and you noticed. She won't know you noticed unless you say so. The same goes for the work nobody else saw, and for the moment you looked over and thought she was beautiful. Familiar affection doesn't get less true because you've said it before.

When she wants it, touch says something words don't. Reach for her hand on a walk. Sit close enough on the couch that she can feel you're there. Find out whether a hug is what helps at the end of a hard day, rather than assuming it is.

You met the five love languages a chapter ago: time together, words, service, gifts, touch. Use the list as an inventory of what you've let fall away. If words are most of what you give her, which of the other four hasn't she had from you in a year?

Do the thing before she asks.

Maybe acts of service are what land best with her. You can ask what would help, and you should listen when she answers. But if every kind thing you do starts with her noticing a task, naming it, and reminding you about it, she's still carrying the part that wears her out: keeping track.

You already know the ordinary work of your house. The dishes are visible. Her car is low on gas. There was an errand she mentioned yesterday. Do it so her day gets easier, then let it go without announcing it and without standing beside the finished task waiting for something. A favor handed over with resentment can leave her wishing she'd done it herself.

You won't guess right every time. She may want to handle something you thought you were rescuing her from. Let her tell you. Taking initiative means

being willing to notice and learn. She knows her own day better than you do. When she does ask, say yes generously. She can ask. She shouldn't have to ask for everything.

Gifts run on the same attention. Once the money is shared, a present bought from the joint account can seem pointless to you. She could have bought it herself. But what the gift tells her is that she was on your mind while she wasn't in the room.

She pointed out a book weeks ago. She loves a particular pastry and never stops for one. You heard her, and one Friday you came home with the book and the pastry. A note left where she'll find it does the same work and costs nothing.

Keep romance off the schedule.

Can you name the last romantic thing you did for her? Not the last date you took her on. A date is one evening. Romance is bigger than that. If you have to count back through months to find one, you've found your starting place.

Romance in your marriage might be breakfast made before she's up, a letter, or an afternoon planned around something she likes now. What counts is knowing her well enough that an ordinary gesture could only have been meant for her. Nothing about it has to be grand.

She told you Monday that her review at work was Wednesday. Asking how it went on Wednesday night is the part she'd notice. She mentioned a restaurant she wants to try, and her favorite flowers aren't the ones you bought five years ago. Remembering counts when you act on it.

Anniversaries and Valentine's Day lose their meaning when you handle them by rote. Ten minutes from home you swing into Walgreens for whatever card is left and a box of chocolate that's been on the shelf since Christmas. You

remembered the date. You gave almost no thought to the woman you were celebrating. Spend the same few dollars with a week's notice and you can give her something she'd actually want. Plan the dinner she'd enjoy. Write down one memory that still makes you glad you married her. Start early enough to mean it.

Some years are crowded and hard. You may both be too tired to plan anything, and a quiet evening at home is an honest way to mark it. You don't owe the calendar a performance. The thing to check is whether you've stopped being thoughtful the rest of the year too.

Don't let knowing her end your learning about her.

Esther Perel is a therapist who writes about desire in long relationships. Her argument is that familiarity can settle into routine, and that curiosity and new experience help keep desire alive. Leave room for the woman beside you to surprise you. Some of what she wanted when you met still matters to her. Some of it doesn't, and she may not have announced the difference.

In 2009, Tsapelas, Aron and Orbuch looked at married couples who had been followed for sixteen years. Spouses who said their marriage felt boring in year seven were less satisfied with it nine years later. That held even after the researchers adjusted for how satisfied each spouse already was in year seven. The study only included couples still married at year sixteen, so it tells you nothing about divorce. The show you watch every week can be familiar and good. Guard against going through every shared hour as though there were nothing left to find out.

Put the phone down, and give her the evening you came to share.

Keep choosing her in ways she can see

when you were dating	now
time together	
words	
service	
gifts	
touch	

Husband is a role you keep playing.

Chapter 13 Distillation — Pursue Her After You Have Her

Mechanism: Keep choosing her in ways she can see

Conversation sentence: You can love your wife and still let the effort that once made her feel chosen disappear from ordinary days.

Pursuit after marriage is attention you give her while you're together and thought you give her while you're apart. Twelve years in, planning a date, you can find you no longer know what she'd want, because you stopped learning about her somewhere along the way. When the effort stops, she can tell you've stopped planning for her. She feels taken for granted, needed and walked past, and she starts asking for less. Put down the phone. Notice a task and carry it through without making her manage it. Say what you admire, offer the touch she welcomes, remember a preference, bring home a small gift, and plan time she would enjoy now. Familiar routines can be lovely; a marriage still needs room for curiosity and gestures that could only have been meant for her.

Lesson: Winning her was the start. You keep showing care through presence, initiative, and romance.

Challenge: Name the last romantic thing you did for her. If you have to reach back months, choose one thoughtful action and follow through without assigning her the planning.

PRACTICE

1. Once a week, choose one thing she would enjoy or benefit from based on something you noticed. Plan and carry it through yourself, whether it is an errand, a small gift, or time together.
2. When she invites you to spend time together, put your phone away and give her your attention. If your mind wanders, come back to the moment you agreed to share.
3. Before an anniversary or Valentine's Day, recall something she enjoys now and plan a gesture around it. Give yourself enough time to make it personal.